Said the Shotgun to the Head

By Saul Williams

INTRODUCTION

Said the Shotgun to the Head by Saul Williams is a mind melding and explosive look at the world we live in, and a call to change that world for the better.

The title "Said the Shotgun to the Head" is attributed by the author to Maya Angelou, who once wrote "someone's writing should be what they would write if they had a gun in their mouth."

Said the Shotgun to the Head by Saul Williams – Unless we see . . . unless we change . . . Let the final countdown to our destruction begin . . . .

10:

CITESENS,
children of the night,
bearers of the day torch:
scorched and burned.
BURN NOT.
the dam is broken.
the curse is fled.

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once muddied and still,
the river runs
RED!

i AM
CERTAIN
i SPEAK A NEW LANGUAGE

as is ALWAYS
THE FIRST SIGN
of a
NEW AGE

i AM COME TO TELL YOU
SHE IS HERE.

i am a simple disoriented man
in her presence

forgive me father
for i have sinned
i prayed to you
and cupped
the wind

and in doing so
barred her entry
into a century:
100 years
of solitude

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(yes, the wind is the moon's imagination wandering)

i will now pray
with my hands

outstretched
with these psalms
etched
into my palms

9:

i am certain of nothing more
than your existence

a thousand ants
crawling under a log
may find themselves exposed
in my childlike search
for you
i have spent lifetimes
in monasteries
and drum stretched
villages
in expectation
of this

my friends laugh at me
and talk behind my back
they say you have
changed me

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and
i am

i am like a survivor
of the flood
walking through the streets
drenched with
God
surprised that all of the
drowned victims
are still walking and talking

maybe there's hope

and then, a feeling. Almost as if nothing were ever bound to repeat itself again. As if history had been as masterfully created as the great pyramids and any attempt to reconstruct or relive any given moment would have to stem from an understanding of how the pyramids were built from the TOP DOWN.
when i can feel you
breathing into me
i, like a stone gargoyle
atop some crumbling building,
spring to life
a resuscitated
angel

i sweep through city streets
my wings out-stretched
making mothers

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clutch their young
and remember

and do you remember, dear ones
or has your history forsaken you?
there were tales told 'round fires
mysteries coded in song
chants and uprisings
centuries of art
all incantations
calling forth this day
s
our mother has returned
to wave us
from uncertainty

rivers
like oceans
oceans
like answers
questions
in cloud forms
raindrops
in stanzas

to be
or not to...

to see
or not to...

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8:

"mother nature's a whore," said the shotgun to the head.

and it smelled like teen spirit
angst driven insecure
a country in puberty
a country at war
cotton mouth
blood thirsty . . . to instill fear

on that glorious day, i stood before my cubicle shuffling papers like a card reader with an oversized deck. the one on top read, "invoice", as something within told me to turn around. she walked the aisle towards me perhaps on the same undisclosed mission that now leads me towards her, only neither of us was confident enough to slow our movements before the first explosion. we, both, stopped, turned back and stared at each other as if shocked that the outside world might bring to life our inner workings.

here is our first touch
and here is this trembling building
hold the two in your hands
and tell me what you come up with

everyone running to windows to see what has happened, as smiles slowly rise on our faces like the time between 6:24 and 6:39 over the skyline. we are not panicked, only

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awed at how a fluttering stomach can predict the short life span of a social butterfly. love has become a fiery place. but we are living in an old testament where there is faith that does not burn, that turns kings into believers.

7:

o my friends,
the greatest americans
have not been born yet
they are waiting patiently
for the past
to die

where is that voice from nowhere
to remind us
that the holy ground
we walk on
purified by native blood
has rooted trees
whose fallen leaves
now color code
a sacred list of demands?

who among us can give translation
of autumn hues to morning news?

the anchor man
thrown overboard
has simply rooted us

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in history's repeating cycle

a nation in its saturn years
that won't acknowledge karma

where is that voice
from nowhere?
the one your prophets spoke of?

there are voices
DEAD to themselves
numb to the possibility
of truth existing beyond
that which they can palm
in the bleeding hole
of their hands,
period.

there are voices of elders
who seem to do no more
than damn us
to our childish ways
for in many households
wisdom
no longer comes with age

so where is that voice from nowhere?

I hear voices of generals
calling for ammunition

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voices of presidents
calling for arms

voices of women
calling for help

but where is that voice
from nowhere?

can he be heard over the gunfire
the whizz of passing missiles
the crash of buildings
the cries of the children
the crack of bones
the shriek of sirens?

or is that his mighty voice?
your angry god

your prayers
between rounds
do no more
than fasten the fate
of your children
to the hammered truth
of your trigger

a truth that mushrooms
its darkened cloud
over the rest of us
so that we too

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bear witness
to the short-lived fate
of a civilization
that worships
a male god

your weapons
are phallic
all of them
a source of madness

a source of hunger for power

a source of weakness

we will wait through the degenerate course
of your repeated history
we will wait for the past to die

6:

pools of blood
are not recreational

the end is near (...)
the beginning

in the beginning her tears were the long awaited rains of a parched somali village. red dusted children danced shadows in the new found mounds of mascara that eclipsed her face, reflected in the smogged glass of

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carlos' east street bodega. learning to love, SHE had
forgotten to cry.

she is within us

a world of dreams
fluid and unremembered
a multitude of tongues
universed

5:

behold, a story untold

i have found the library
where all dreams deferred
were stored

catologues of cultures
indexed by communal disappearance

mayans are metaphors
for astral doors
left cracked
by children afraid
to sleep in utter darkness

come see
how death is a myth

there are no deceased

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only deceived
death only awaits
those who believed

i surrendered
my beliefs

i am the dead's latest experiment
a midwife birthing afterlife

the unborn are fully present
we have disguised ourselves
from ourselves
so that our daily thoughts
may not sabotage
our spirits'
ascendance

we have been forced
to create a new currency

one that will truly allow us
to love our neighbors
for reasons beyond guilt and pity

4:

introduce me
to your after-life
let me see
if i can tempt it

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from its cloud form

those white robes
are the very cloaks
of your enemies
and their leader
has the brazen tone
of your shepherd

maybe you shouldn't have prayed
with your eyes closed

open eyes plainly see
the resemblance

a prayer stamped
return to sender

tables over turned
in a temple

bitten apples
that encourage you
to think different

this is no blasphemy
i am only revealing
what is hidden
under the floating
white sheet

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you cower behind your God
as he leads you into slavery
and war

your children drown
in the cross-fire

you have done nothing
to protect them
from the evil eye

not even when every sign
tells you that you should

you father's diet
kills him
and you hire
his chef

you wage war
on minimum wage
and the people
purchase their delicacies
from Target

maybe you should aim
elsewhere

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3:

intelligence is intuitive
you needn't learn to love
unless you've been taught
to fear and hate

your students
kill each other
and their teachers

they are angry
at not being taught

and those
who do not know
their history
are bound to repeat it

you keep your gun
in your desk drawer

movies have taught you
your hiding places

silver screens with bare walls
behind them
the illustrators of bare walls
projected their dreams
beyond their fears
theirs were the walls

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of pyramids

yours are the walls
of crumbled towers

the truth still stands

you sit behind your desk
ready to aim
at the cloaked thief
in your temple

you are a cocked trigger
smuggled into a house of prayer

2:

i came to know her
before she overthrew
my government

it was no conspiracy
only an unraveling
of a fist

her charm
is in her silence
she speaks
in extended parenthesis

hers is the voice from nowhere

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fathered by sun and sky
we are offspring of spring
reborn from the bounty
of her nourishment

we set our table at twilight
and hold hands
offering grace to the wind
acknowledging that even he who shines
was born out of the mystery
of her darkness

our mother holds no judgment
she absorbs our father's light
into her flesh and blood
regenerating
an offspring universal

God is a single mother

1:

what is the cost of freedom?
and how is it paid?

to be free
of the rigmarole
of age old traditions
based on submission and fear
one must pay with the courage
to stand alone

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to be free
of the restraints
of a culture
that instills the will
of material possession and domination
into its citizens
one must learn to honor
the substance of their materials
and the etymological roots
of their findings

mater: fr. Latin.meaning mother
this IS a material word

your priests and presidents
no longer matter

in order to commune
we must dismiss the false gods
we have granted domain
over our will and testament

this earth is our sanctuary
nothing more need be built

our mother
has erected
mountains of quartz
we only need climb
to synchronize our hearts

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with hers

the truth
erupts from her core

we court a corrupted institution
subject to the division of its faculty

we are tenured students of intuition

professors of a truth beyond reason
schooled in the overpriced cities
in the valleys of our consciousness

come, my love
we have mountains to climb
wilderness to wander

come,
we have oceans to sail

they have ravished
your heart and mind
but your breath
travels freely
it is only a matter of time
before we are timeless

do you feel it yet?

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wow

take deeper breaths

wow

what happens to a society
when mystery is labeled
as evil?

it yields an ever-connected chain
of false labels and misinterpretations

the indigenous are labeled
as savage terrorists
and plotted against

the open-hearted
are manipulated into slavery

the vulnerable are penetrated
by force of law

citizens
where is your allegiance?
why do you pledge
with a covered heart
when it needs to be opened?

why do you bear arms
with balled fists

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and closed palms?

why do you call yourself
a patriot (pater: fr. Latin.meaning father)
when your greatest love has always been
for your mother?

you've worshipped
loopholes in a story
and war shipped
mythic men to glory

if in god's image
then your god's
a plastic surgeon

a tyrannic dictator

a coward behind a curtain
with a megaphone

an aging oil tycoon
on viagra
ramming his plow
into the earth
turning up disease
and disaster
out of an ever-drying womb
where children use chalk
on the sidewalk
tracing their bodies

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for the pre-criminal investigation:
of their paternal inheritance:

murder!

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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